

A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR HOMEOWNERS

Selling Your Home

Pricing · Prep · Marketing · Offers · Closing

Plain answers. Ohio specifics. No sales pitch.

Flip this book over for the Buyer's Guide



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*Serving Lima and the surrounding
Northwest Ohio communities*



A quick note from me

Selling a house is one of the bigger financial moves most people make, and it's usually happening on top of everything else in life: a job change, a growing family, a divorce, a parent who needs you closer. This side of the book is the seller's half. It walks through how a sale actually works, what Ohio law requires, what it costs, and where deals go sideways.

It's written the way I'd explain it across a kitchen table. No jargon I can avoid, no scare tactics, and no pretending the process is harder than it is so you'll feel like you need me. If you read this and decide to handle it yourself, I'd still rather you do it well.

A little about me: I've lived and worked in Northwest Ohio most of my life. Before real estate I spent 18 years as a cardiac nurse and 26 years in the Air National Guard. I'm a Dad, a Veteran, and your neighbor. I'm not a high-pressure person, and I don't work with people who want one.

Flip the book over for the buyer's half. If you're doing both at once, the two sides meet in the middle.

— Scott

How to use this side

Pages 4–5 (pricing) are the ones to read first. Then work forward: prep, marketing, paperwork, offers, closing. The checklist on page 13 is meant to be torn out.

How a sale actually works

Most sales in our area follow the same seven steps. Knowing the order takes a lot of the anxiety out of it.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Price it
Pull closed comparable sales, adjust honestly, land at or just under a search bracket. Two weeks of market feedback tells you if you're right. |
| 2 | Prep it
Declutter, deep clean, fix the small stuff, professional photos. Remove reasons to say no. |
| 3 | Market it
MLS exposure syndicates to Zillow, Realtor.com and every agent's buyers. Sign, social, open house. |
| 4 | Show it
Lockbox and showing app; you leave, buyers talk honestly, feedback comes back through me. |
| 5 | Negotiate the offer
Evaluate on net proceeds and certainty of closing, not headline price. |
| 6 | Inspection to appraisal
Repair requests, appraisal, title work, lender underwriting. This is where deals are saved or lost. |
| 7 | Close
Sign the deed, funds wire after recording, hand over keys. Typically 30–45 days after accepted offer. |

91%

of 2025 sellers used
a real estate agent

30–45

days from accepted
offer to closing

14

days of market feedback
tells you if the price is
right

Source: NAR 2025 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers; local closing timelines.

STEP 1

Pricing it right

Price is the decision everything else depends on. Buyers see every new listing within hours and compare it to what sold last month. A house priced right gets showings in the first two weeks. A house priced high gets silence, then a cut, then a lower final number than if it had started right.

How I price a house

- **Closed sales only.** Not listings, not estimates. Three to five homes that a real buyer actually paid for in the last six months, in your area, with similar size, style, and age.
- **Adjust both directions.** Your newer roof is worth something. So is the busy road. The buyer will count both.
- **What's pending and what's sitting.** Pendings show where the market is going. Stale listings show where it won't go.
- **Search brackets.** Buyers search "up to \$200,000." A house at \$204,900 is invisible to them. Price at or just under the line.

The Zestimate trap

Online estimates don't know your roof is 22 years old or that your kitchen was redone last year. In smaller Ohio markets with fewer sales they can miss by 10% or more in either direction.

Three pricing mistakes that cost the most

- **"Leave room to negotiate."** Overpricing by 5–8% doesn't create room; it removes showings. Buyers don't negotiate with a house they never walk through.
- **Pricing off what you need.** Your payoff, your next down payment, and what the deck cost are real to you and invisible to the buyer.
- **Chasing the market down.** Small cuts every few weeks signal a seller who'll keep cutting. If it isn't moving after three weeks of real exposure, one meaningful correction beats four small ones.

Read the market's answer

- **Showings but no offers** → the price is close; something about the house is talking buyers out of it.
- **Few or no showings** → the price is filtering people out before they come.
- **Multiple offers in days** → you may have left money on the table. It happens, and it's better than the alternative.

Timing

In our area, spring and early summer bring the most buyers, but they also bring the most competition. A well-priced, well-presented house sells in any month. What matters more than the season is being ready on day one: the first two weeks of a listing get more attention than the next two months.

Free, no-strings pricing opinion

If you're months away from selling and just want a number to plan around, call or text me. I'll pull the comps and walk you through them. No listing appointment required.

STEP 2

Getting it ready

Buyers decide in the first eight seconds on a screen and the first sixty at the door. Preparation isn't about perfect; it's about removing reasons to say no.

The high-return list

- ☐ Declutter every flat surface. Half of what's on counters and shelves goes into boxes now.
- ☐ Deep clean, including windows, baseboards, and inside the oven. Hire it out if you can.
- ☐ Neutral touch-up paint where walls are scuffed. Fill nail holes.
- ☐ Fix what the inspector will list anyway: drips, loose handrails, missing outlet covers, running toilets.
- ☐ Same warm-white bulb in every fixture. Every light on for photos and showings.
- ☐ Curb appeal: mow, edge, mulch, trim, power-wash the walk, new mat at the door.
- ☐ Smell check by someone who doesn't live there. Pets, smoke, and basement damp are deal-killers you've stopped noticing.

Skip these

Major kitchen or bath remodels rarely return their cost right before a sale. New carpet in one bad room, yes. A \$30,000 kitchen, no. Ask me before you spend real money; I'll tell you what buyers here actually pay for.

Photos and presentation

Your photos are your open house. Most buyers will never see the inside if the pictures don't get them there. That's why professional photography is part of every listing I take, at no cost to you, along with a floor plan and video where it helps.

- Before the shoot: TV off, toilet lids down, trash cans and dish racks hidden, fridge magnets off, cars out of the driveway.
- Twenty to thirty photos. Exterior first, kitchen second, living space third. No blurry ones.
- Staging doesn't mean renting furniture. It means fewer things, better placed, and light in every room.

Showings

A five-minute "show ready" routine: lights on, blinds open, dishes away, beds made, pets out, comfortable temperature. Then leave. Buyers won't talk honestly in front of the owner, and honest reactions are what I need to hear. Showings are scheduled through an app so you always know who's coming and when, and you can decline a time that doesn't work.

Pre-listing inspection?

Paying for your own inspection (\$350-\$450) before you list means no surprises during the buyer's inspection, which is where more deals die than anywhere else. Fix what you can, disclose what you can't, price accordingly.

STEP 3

Getting it in front of buyers

The buyers who pay the most are the ones searching online tonight from Columbus, Dayton, Fort Wayne, or three towns over. Reaching them is the job.

What a listing with me includes

- **MLS exposure.** Your home goes to every agent in the region and syndicates automatically to Zillow, Realtor.com, Homes.com, and hundreds of other sites in the main feed, not the "other listings" section.
- **Professional photos, floor plan, and video** where it helps.
- **Social and digital.** Targeted posts and ads to buyers who are actually looking in our area.
- **Agent network.** I tell the agents who have buyers waiting for exactly your kind of house before it hits the market.
- **Open house with a QR code** that gives visitors the full listing, photos, and a way to reach me on their phone.
- **Yard sign with a readable phone number** and a QR code for the drive-bys.

Write it like a buyer, not an owner

Lead with what buyers filter on: beds, baths, square footage, garage, lot size, year built, school district, taxes. Then three or four sentences on what's actually notable. Skip "cozy" and "must see."

Have your numbers ready

Every serious buyer asks: annual property taxes, average utilities, ages of roof/furnace/AC/water heater, and what stays. We'll put that on one sheet and leave copies by the door.

STEP 4

Ohio paperwork, handled

Two documents are required in almost every residential sale in Ohio. With a listed home I make sure they're done right and delivered on time; the risk of getting them wrong is real either way.

Residential Property Disclosure Form

Ohio law (R.C. 5302.30) requires you to complete the state's form and give it to the buyer **before** they sign a purchase contract. You disclose what you actually know about water, sewer, roof, basement, structure, mechanicals, pests, drainage, and more.

- Honest and complete. "Unknown" is a legitimate answer; a blank or a guess is not.
- If a buyer gets the form late, they can cancel the contract within three business days of receiving it, right up until closing.
- A disclosed defect is the buyer's decision. An undisclosed one is a lawsuit after closing. When in doubt, write it down.

Lead-based paint (homes built before 1978)

Federal law requires a separate lead disclosure, the EPA pamphlet, and a 10-day window for the buyer to test. A large share of the housing stock in our area is pre-1978, so this applies to most sellers.

Agency disclosure

Ohio requires me to give you the Consumer Guide to Agency Relationships at our first real conversation and an Agency Disclosure Statement before any contract. It spells out exactly who I represent, which is you.

STEP 5

Reading an offer

The headline price is the least important number on the page. Here's what I look at with you, in order:

- **Net to you.** Price minus concessions, repair credits, and any buyer's-agent compensation you're being asked to cover. A net sheet turns two different offers into one honest comparison.
- **Certainty of closing.** Cash, conventional with 20% down, or FHA with 3.5%? A strong pre-approval from a local lender is worth real money because it's less likely to fall apart in week four.
- **Contingencies.** Inspection (usually 7–10 days), appraisal, financing, and sometimes the sale of the buyer's current home. Fewer and shorter is stronger.
- **Timeline and possession.** Does their closing date work for where you're going? Do they need to move in the day of closing, or can you have a few days?
- **What conveys.** Appliances, window treatments, the shed. Settle it in the contract, not at the walk-through.

Buyer's-agent compensation, since 2024

Buyers now sign a written agreement with their agent that states what the agent is paid. Their offer may ask you to cover some or all of it as a concession. You are never required to. We decide your position before the listing goes live so you're never deciding it under pressure, and we evaluate every offer on net.

Multiple offers

Set a deadline, ask for highest and best once, and compare on net and certainty. The highest number with a shaky loan is often the worst offer on the table.

STEP 6

From accepted offer to keys

A typical financed sale takes 30–45 days from accepted offer to closing; cash can close in two weeks. Here's what's happening in between:

Days 1–10

Inspection

Buyer's inspector visits for 2–3 hours. Expect a repair or credit request. We respond in writing, keep it specific, and don't reopen the whole deal.

Days 5–20

Appraisal & loan

Lender orders the appraisal; underwriting proceeds. If the appraisal comes in low, we have options: renegotiate, buyer covers the gap, or meet in the middle.

Days 10–30

Title work

Title company searches title, clears liens, orders your payoff, prepares the deed.

Days 25–40

Clear to close

Lender issues final approval. Title company sends the settlement statement showing your exact net. We read every line together.

Day before

Final walk-through

Buyer confirms the house is in the agreed condition and the agreed items are there. Clean, empty, keys and manuals on the counter.

Closing

Sign & fund

You sign the deed and closing documents. Funds wire after recording. Keys change hands as the contract says.

Wire fraud is real

Never accept wiring instructions by email without confirming by phone at a number you looked up yourself. Sellers have lost entire proceeds this way.

STEP 7

What it costs to sell

Plan for these so the settlement statement isn't a surprise. Customs vary by county; the title company confirms the exact figures and I'll run a net sheet before you accept any offer.

- **Ohio conveyance fee.** State plus county, commonly \$3–\$4 per \$1,000 of sale price. On \$200,000, that's \$600–\$800. Seller customarily pays.
- **Owner's title insurance policy.** Sometimes requested by the buyer in the offer, but you are never obligated to pay it. In my experience buyers here rarely ask; if they do, it's a negotiable item like any other.
- **Title exam, deed prep, settlement fee.** Roughly \$300–\$700 combined.
- **Property tax proration.** Ohio taxes are paid *in arrears*, so you credit the buyer for taxes covering the time you owned the home that haven't been billed yet. This surprises almost everyone.
- **Mortgage payoff** with interest through funding, plus the release recording fee.
- **Negotiated items.** Repair credits, buyer's-agent compensation you agree to, a home warranty if offered.
- **Real estate compensation.** Negotiable, stated in dollars and percentages in writing before you sign a listing agreement. We'll talk about it openly and early.

Ask for a seller net sheet

I'll run one for any price you're considering, free, same day, so you're comparing on what you'll actually walk away with.

The seller checklist

Before you list

- ☐ Pricing conversation with real comps; agree on list price and a bracket strategy
- ☐ Residential Property Disclosure Form completed honestly
- ☐ Lead-paint disclosure if pre-1978
- ☐ One-page fact sheet: taxes, utilities, ages of roof/HVAC/water heater, what stays
- ☐ Declutter, deep clean, touch-up paint, fix the small stuff
- ☐ Professional photos scheduled; show-ready routine set
- ☐ Decide your position on buyer's-agent compensation
- ☐ Know your next move: where you're going and when (see pages 15–16)

While it's on the market

- ☐ Showing app set up; you know how to accept and decline
- ☐ Every showing gets feedback; we review it weekly
- ☐ Offers compared on a net sheet, not headline price
- ☐ Two-week check-in: price holding or one correction?

Under contract

- ☐ Inspection response in writing by the deadline
- ☐ Respond same-day to title company and lender requests
- ☐ Confirm wiring instructions by phone, never email alone
- ☐ Walk-through ready: clean, empty, agreed items in place
- ☐ Keys, remotes, codes, manuals in a bag on the counter

What I actually do for a seller

Here's the honest version of the job, so you can decide whether it's worth what it costs.

- **Price it from real data** and tell you the truth about the number, including when it's lower than you hoped.
- **Get it in front of every buyer:** MLS, syndication, professional photos, social, my agent network, open house.
- **Handle showings and feedback** so you're not fielding calls at 9 p.m. or letting strangers in alone.
- **Negotiate with the other side's agent** on price, repairs, appraisal gaps, and timelines. This is where experience pays for itself.
- **Keep the closing on the rails:** deadlines, documents, title, lender, and the twenty small things that go wrong in week three.
- **Keep the paperwork legal.** Disclosures delivered on time, contracts that hold up.

How I get paid

My compensation is negotiable and we'll put it in writing, in dollars, before you sign anything. If we agree to offer compensation to a buyer's agent, that's your decision too. No surprises on the settlement statement.

Or don't hire anyone

If you'd rather sell it yourself, ask me for my FSBO guide. It's the same information, written for someone doing it alone, and the offer of a free pricing opinion stands.

Selling and buying at the same time

Most sellers in our area are also buyers. That's the hardest version of a move, and it's the one where a plan matters most. There are three ways to sequence it; each has a cost.

Sell first, then buy

Cleanest financially. You know your exact proceeds, you're a non-contingent buyer, and sellers take you seriously. The cost is the gap: you may need a short-term rental, storage, or a **post-closing occupancy agreement** (you rent your old house back from the buyer for a few weeks). Those are common here and I negotiate them regularly.

Buy first, then sell

Best for your sanity, hardest on your wallet. You need to qualify for two payments or use a bridge loan or HELOC on the current house, and you carry both until the old one sells. Works when your current home is very marketable and you have cash cushion.

Contingent offer

You offer on the new house contingent on selling yours. Sellers accept these more readily in a slower market or with a **kick-out clause**: if another buyer appears, you get 48–72 hours to drop the contingency or walk. Your offer is stronger if your house is already listed, priced right, and photographed.

Making both closings land

- **Same-day closings are normal.** Sell in the morning, buy in the afternoon; the title company wires proceeds from one into the other. I coordinate both timelines with both lenders and both title companies.
- **Build a buffer.** Ask for possession on your purchase a few days after your sale closes, or a rent-back on your sale. Moving day and closing day should not be the same day if you can help it.
- **Get pre-approved before you list.** Knowing what you can buy tells us what your sale needs to net, and it sets a floor for the price conversation.
- **Don't move money around.** Lenders want to see stable accounts. Big deposits or transfers in the middle of underwriting cause delays.
- **One point of contact.** When the same person is running your sale and your purchase, nothing falls between the two.

What I'll ask you at the first meeting

- What does the next house need to be, and by when?
- How much cash do you have beyond the sale proceeds?
- Could you carry two payments for 60 days if you had to?
- Would you rather move twice with certainty, or once with some risk?

The two sides meet here

This is the center of the book. Flip it over and you're reading the buyer's half, which ends on this same topic from the other direction.

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A quick note from me

Buying a house is exciting for about a week and then it's mostly paperwork, waiting, and decisions you've never had to make before. This side of the book is the buyer's half. It walks through money first, then the search, the offer, the inspection, and closing, with the Ohio-specific parts called out.

It's written the way I'd explain it across a kitchen table. I'll tell you what things cost, what can go wrong, and what I actually do for you, so you can decide whether you want help.

A little about me: I've lived and worked in Northwest Ohio most of my life. Before real estate I spent 18 years as a cardiac nurse and 26 years in the Air National Guard, which is why there's a page in here about VA loans that I wish someone had handed me at 25. I'm a Dad, a Veteran, and your neighbor. I'm not a high-pressure person.

Flip the book over for the seller's half. If you're doing both at once, the two sides meet in the middle.

— Scott

How to use this side

Read page 4 (money) before you look at a single house online. Then work forward. The checklist on page 13 is meant to be torn out.

How buying actually works

Eight steps, in order. Most people try to start at step 4. Start at step 1 and the rest gets easier.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Get pre-approved
A real pre-approval from a lender, not an online pre-qual. It tells you what you can spend and makes your offer credible. |
| 2 | Know your all-in number
Down payment plus closing costs plus reserves. Page 5. |
| 3 | Sign a buyer agreement
Required in Ohio before I show you homes. It spells out what I do and what I'm paid. Page 6. |
| 4 | Search
Needs vs. wants, the right towns, and how to look at a house with your eyes open. Page 7. |
| 5 | Offer
Price, earnest money, contingencies, and the terms that win without overpaying. Page 8. |
| 6 | Inspect
7–10 days to learn what you're really buying, and to negotiate or walk. Page 9. |
| 7 | Appraisal, title, underwriting
The quiet weeks where you must not change anything about your finances. Page 10. |
| 8 | Close & move in
Sign, fund, keys. And the three things to do in your first 30 days. Page 11. |

30–45

days from accepted
offer to closing

7–10

days is a typical
inspection period

2–5%

of price is a typical
buyer closing-cost range

Get your money right first

Pre-qualification vs. pre-approval

A pre-qual is a guess based on what you typed into a website. A **pre-approval** means a lender pulled your credit, verified income and assets, and put a number in writing. Sellers in our area know the difference. Get the real one, ideally from a local lender who answers the phone.

Loan types you'll hear about

- **Conventional.** As little as 3% down for first-time buyers; PMI until you reach 20% equity. Strongest offer in the seller's eyes.
- **FHA.** 3.5% down, more forgiving on credit, but mortgage insurance for the life of the loan in most cases and stricter property-condition rules.
- **VA.** If you served: no down payment, no monthly mortgage insurance, competitive rates. See page 12.
- **USDA.** No down payment for eligible rural areas, and much of Northwest Ohio outside the city limits qualifies. Income limits apply.
- **Ohio Housing Finance Agency (OHFA).** State programs with down-payment assistance for first-time and moderate-income buyers. Ask your lender if you qualify; many don't mention it unless asked.

Down payment myths

You do not need 20% down. Most first-time buyers in our area put down 3–5%. What you do need is cash for closing costs and a cushion for the first repair, which is why page 5 matters.

STEP 2

What it really costs to buy

The purchase price is the big number. These are the ones that catch people off guard. Your lender's Loan Estimate spells them out; here's what they mean.

- **Earnest money.** Your good-faith deposit with the offer, typically \$500–\$2,000 in our area. Held by the title company and credited back to you at closing.
- **Closing costs.** Roughly 2–5% of the price: lender fees, appraisal (\$450–\$650), credit report, lender's title policy, title/settlement fees, recording. On \$200,000, plan on \$4,000–\$8,000.
- **Prepays and escrow.** The first year of homeowner's insurance and a few months of property taxes deposited up front so your lender can pay them for you.
- **Inspection.** \$350–\$450 for a general inspection. Add radon, well, septic, or termite where they apply (page 9).
- **Ohio tax proration works in your favor.** Property taxes are paid in arrears, so the seller credits you at closing for the months they owned the home. That credit offsets some of your prepaids.
- **Seller concessions.** You can ask the seller to pay some of your closing costs. In a competitive situation it weakens your offer; in a slower one it's common.

Cash to close, one number

Down payment + closing costs + prepaids – earnest money – seller credits = cash to close. I'll build that number with you before you offer, so there is no surprise the week of closing.

STEP 3

The buyer agreement, and how I get paid

Since 2024, agents everywhere must have a written agreement with a buyer before showing homes. It changed how the business works, mostly for the better, because it made compensation transparent.

What the agreement says

- Who I represent: you. Not the seller, not the lender.
- What I'm paid, stated in dollars or a percentage, and that it's negotiable.
- Where that money comes from: it can be paid by you, by the seller as a concession in the offer, or a combination. Most sellers in our area still offer something. If they don't, we ask for it in the offer.
- How long it lasts and how you end it if we're not a fit.

Ohio's agency disclosures

Ohio also requires the Consumer Guide to Agency Relationships at our first real conversation and an Agency Disclosure Statement before you sign a contract. Both are plain-language forms about who represents whom. If an agent skips them, that tells you something.

What you should expect from me

Same-day showings when possible, honest opinions about houses (including "walk away"), a cash-to-close number before every offer, and a negotiation plan you understand. If I ever push you toward a house you're not sure about, call me on it.

Open houses and the listing agent

The agent at an open house works for the seller. Be friendly, don't share your budget or timeline, and don't sign anything there.

STEP 4

The search

Needs, wants, and dealbreakers

Write three short lists before you look. **Needs** are the things you can't change: location, bedrooms, a garage, one-floor living. **Wants** are nice: the updated kitchen, the fenced yard. **Dealbreakers** are the quiet ones: a busy road, a wet basement, no mudroom in a house full of kids. Most regret comes from ignoring a dealbreaker because the kitchen was pretty.

How to look at a house in our area

Much of our housing stock was built before 1980. That's not a problem; it's a checklist.

- **Roof and gutters.** Ask the age. Look for lifted shingles, moss, and staining on ceilings inside.
- **Basement.** Look for efflorescence (white powder on block), water lines on walls, a sump pump, and how the yard drains toward the house.
- **Furnace, AC, water heater.** Ages on the label. Twenty-plus years means budget for replacement.
- **Windows and electrical.** Original windows and a fuse box or 100-amp panel are common and workable, but they cost money.
- **Rural:** ask about the well, the septic, and who maintains the road.

The 10-minute rule

If you're still in the house after ten minutes without being asked to leave, you like it. Trust that, then verify it with an inspection.

STEP 5

Making an offer

An offer is more than a price. Here's what's in it and how each piece makes you stronger or weaker in a seller's eyes:

- **Price.** Based on closed comps, not the list price. Some homes are underpriced to draw a crowd; some are overpriced and sitting.
- **Earnest money.** More shows commitment. It's refundable if you walk during your contingencies.
- **Financing.** Your pre-approval letter goes with the offer. Conventional reads stronger than FHA; cash reads strongest.
- **Inspection contingency.** Usually 7–10 days. Shortening it strengthens the offer; waiving it is rarely wise.
- **Appraisal contingency.** Protects you if the appraisal comes in low. In a bidding war, an **appraisal gap** clause (you cover up to \$X above appraisal) can win without waiving protection entirely.
- **Closing date and possession.** Matching the seller's timeline can beat a higher price.
- **Escalation clause.** "I'll beat any other offer by \$1,000 up to \$X." Useful in multiple-offer situations; I'll tell you when.

Multiple offers

Decide your walk-away number before you write the offer, not at 9 p.m. when the listing agent calls for highest and best. The house you overpaid for is not a win.

Sight-unseen and "love letters"

I'll never recommend either. Letters to the seller can create fair-housing problems, and a house you haven't walked through is a house you don't know.

STEP 6

The inspection

You'll have 7–10 days after acceptance. A general inspection takes 2–3 hours and costs \$350–\$450. Go. Walk with the inspector. You'll learn more about the house that afternoon than in any showing.

What a general inspection doesn't cover

- **Radon.** Common in Ohio. A 48-hour test is about \$150. Mitigation, if needed, runs \$800–\$1,500 and is often negotiable.
- **Well and septic.** Required for most rural loans and smart regardless. Separate tests, separate fees.
- **Termite / wood-destroying insects.** Required for VA loans; cheap insurance for anyone.
- **Sewer scope** on older homes with big trees near the line. A camera down the main line can save you a \$6,000 surprise.

Negotiating repairs

The inspection report will be long. Every house has a list. The question isn't "is there a list?" but "what on it is safety, structure, or major systems?" We ask for those, as a repair or a credit, and we let the cosmetic items go. A reasonable request keeps the deal together; a 40-item list makes the seller walk.

If it's bad enough, walk

That's what the contingency is for. Your earnest money comes back, and the right house is still out there. I'll tell you honestly when I think you should.

STEP 7

Appraisal, title, and the quiet weeks

After inspection, the lender orders an appraisal, the title company searches the title, and underwriting reviews everything about you one more time. Your job in these weeks is mostly to **not change anything**.

Do not, until you have keys

- Change jobs, go part-time, or become self-employed.
- Buy a truck, furniture, or appliances on credit. Not even 0% financing.
- Open or close credit cards, or co-sign for anyone.
- Move money between accounts or deposit large cash without a paper trail.
- Miss a payment on anything.

If the appraisal comes in low

The lender will only lend on the appraised value. Options: the seller reduces the price, you cover the difference in cash, you meet in the middle, or you walk under the appraisal contingency. Pricing your offer off real comps makes this rare.

Homeowner's insurance

Shop it early. Your lender needs proof before closing, and rates vary widely for older homes and rural properties.

Wire fraud is real

You'll wire your cash to close. Call the title company at a number you looked up yourself to confirm the instructions before sending a dollar. Never trust wiring details that arrive by email alone.

STEP 8

Closing day and your first 30 days

Closing

- You'll get the **Closing Disclosure** at least three business days before. Read it against your Loan Estimate; the numbers should be close. We go through it together.
- **Final walk-through** the day before or morning of. Agreed repairs done, agreed items present, nothing new broken.
- Bring a photo ID. The cash to close is wired ahead of time (see page 10).
- Signing takes about an hour. Funds are released after the deed is recorded, usually the same day. Then keys.

The first 30 days

- **Change the locks** and garage codes. You have no idea who has a key.
- **File for the Owner-Occupancy Credit** with your county auditor. Ohio gives a 2.5% reduction on some property taxes for the home you live in. It's a one-page form and it's free.
- **Transfer utilities** on closing day, not after. Some rural providers need a week's notice.
- **Find the shutoffs:** water main, gas, electrical panel. Label them before you need them at 2 a.m.
- **Keep the closing packet** somewhere you'll find it at tax time.

If you served, or this is your first

The VA loan, from someone who served

I spent 26 years in the Air National Guard, and the VA loan is the best benefit most veterans never use. Guard and Reserve members qualify with sufficient service, not just active duty.

- **Zero down payment** and **no monthly mortgage insurance**, which is the part that changes the math.
- A one-time **funding fee** (waived entirely if you have a VA disability rating) can be rolled into the loan.
- Rates are typically as good as or better than conventional.
- The VA appraisal has minimum property requirements, so some fixer-uppers won't qualify. We shop with that in mind.
- You can use it more than once, and the seller can pay your closing costs.

First-time buyers

- Ask your lender about **OHFA** programs and any city or county down-payment assistance. Money is left on the table every year because nobody asked.
- Buy less than the maximum you're approved for. The number the bank gives you is what you *can* pay, not what you should.
- A house needs a repair fund from day one. \$2,000–\$5,000 set aside at closing keeps a broken water heater from becoming a crisis.
- You will not find the perfect house. You'll find a good one, and you'll make it yours.

The buyer checklist

Before you look

- ☐ Real pre-approval from a lender (not an online pre-qual)
- ☐ Cash-to-close number built: down payment + costs + prepaids + reserve
- ☐ Needs / wants / dealbreakers written down
- ☐ Buyer agreement signed; agency disclosures received
- ☐ Homeowner's insurance quotes started

When you find it

- ☐ Comps pulled; offer price and walk-away number set before writing
- ☐ Earnest money ready; pre-approval letter attached to offer
- ☐ Inspection scheduled inside the contingency window
- ☐ Radon / well / septic / termite / sewer scope as applicable
- ☐ Repair request: safety, structure, systems only

Under contract

- ☐ No new credit, no job changes, no big transfers
- ☐ Appraisal ordered; insurance bound
- ☐ Closing Disclosure reviewed against Loan Estimate
- ☐ Wire instructions confirmed by phone
- ☐ Final walk-through done
- ☐ Utilities transferred for closing day

First 30 days

- ☐ Locks and codes changed
- ☐ Owner-Occupancy Credit filed with county auditor
- ☐ Shutoffs located and labeled

What I actually do for a buyer

The honest version, so you can decide.

- **Get you to the right lender and the right loan.** Conventional vs. FHA vs. VA vs. USDA changes your monthly payment by hundreds. I've seen all of them close here.
- **Find the houses**, including the ones about to hit the market, and get you in fast.
- **Tell you the truth in the driveway.** Roof, basement, mechanicals, road noise, resale. Including "don't."
- **Write an offer that wins without overpaying**, and hold your walk-away number when the pressure hits.
- **Run the inspection negotiation** so it gets you what matters and keeps the deal alive.
- **Keep the closing on the rails:** lender, title, appraisal, insurance, and the twenty small things that go wrong in week three.

How I get paid

It's in the buyer agreement, in writing, before we look at a house. Most sellers in our area offer compensation to the buyer's agent; when they don't, we ask for it in the offer. You'll never be surprised by it at closing.

No pressure, ever

If you're a year away and just want to understand the numbers, call anyway. A 20-minute conversation now saves months later.

Buying and selling at the same time

If you own a home now, you're not just a buyer; you're a buyer whose down payment is locked up in a house that hasn't sold yet. That's the hardest version of a move, and it's the one where a plan matters most.

Where does the down payment come from?

For most move-up buyers, it's the equity in the current home, which only becomes cash at that closing. Your options:

- **Sell first.** You know your proceeds and you're a non-contingent buyer. The gap between closings is covered with a short rental, family, or a **post-closing occupancy agreement** (rent your old house back for a few weeks).
- **Bridge loan or HELOC** on the current house lets you buy first. You carry two payments until the old one sells; your lender has to qualify you for both.
- **Contingent offer.** You offer on the new house contingent on selling yours. Stronger if your house is already listed and priced right; expect a **kick-out clause** that gives you 48–72 hours to drop the contingency if another buyer appears.

Talk to the lender first

Before you fall in love with a listing, your lender needs to tell you which of these you qualify for. Some buyers can carry two payments on paper; most can't. Knowing that changes the whole plan.

Making both closings land

- **Same-day closings are normal.** Sell in the morning, buy in the afternoon; the title company moves the proceeds across. I coordinate both timelines with both lenders and both title companies.
- **Build a buffer.** Ask for possession on your purchase a few days after your sale closes, or a rent-back on your sale. Moving day and closing day should not be the same day if you can help it.
- **Price the sale to sell.** A contingent offer is only as strong as the listing behind it. An overpriced current home sinks the purchase too.
- **Don't move money around.** Lenders want stable accounts. The sale proceeds will show up with a paper trail; everything else should stay put.
- **One point of contact.** When the same person runs your sale and your purchase, nothing falls between the two.

What I'll ask you at the first meeting

- What does the next house need to be, and by when?
- How much cash do you have beyond the sale proceeds?
- Could you carry two payments for 60 days if you had to?
- Would you rather move twice with certainty, or once with some risk?

The two sides meet here

This is the center of the book. Flip it over and you're reading the seller's half, which ends on this same topic from the other direction.